

generation, who were deeply touched by the movement for Indian Independence and began tackling the important social and political questions of the day in radical ways. What made Anand unique was the longevity and consistency of his commitment to build an independent India, which would fulfill its promises to all of its citizens and the rest of the world.

Born in Peshawar in 1905, Anand went to Khalsa College in Amritsar. In the 1920s, he participated in a student strike against the transfer of a nationalist principal after Annie Besant had been invited to give a talk. The strike landed him in jail for a month and immediately created tensions with his loyalist father, eventually forcing him to leave home. With the help of Muhammad Iqbal, Anand earned a scholarship to attend London University where he earned a Ph.D. in philosophy.

In England, he circulated around the fringes of the Bloomsbury Group and other modernist writers and thinkers: he met Leonard and Virginia Woolf; worked for T.S. Eliot's *Criterion*, and befriended E.M. Forster and George Orwell. Anand went on to teach at a number of English universities and work as a broadcaster and scriptwriter for the BBC during the Second World War.

It was in the headiness of this political and literary milieu that Anand composed the two novels for which he is most famous: *Untouchable* (1935) and *Coolie* (1936). These novels—along with Raja Rao's *Kanthapura*, R.K. Narayan's *Swami and Friends*, and Ahmed Ali's *Twilight in Delhi*—inaugurated an Indian fiction in English whose heirs have achieved remarkable heights in the terrain opened up by a few pioneers.

At the same time, Anand was also a remarkable polemicist for Indian



Q: What was his first piece of writing?

A: His letter to God as an 11-year-old asking why his nine-year-old cousin had died

Q: Which of his works is semi-autobiographical in nature?

A: *The Private Life of an Indian Prince* (1953)

Q: Which incident influenced his early writing the most?

A: The suicide by an aunt, who was excommunicated for dining with a Muslim woman

Q: Where did he write the first draft of his novel *Untouchable*?

A: At Mahatma Gandhi's ashram in Wardha

Q: He is compared to which famous Victorian novelist?

A: Charles Dickens

Independence. He wrote *Letters on India* (1942) and *Apology for Heroism* (1946), two pamphlets which were designed to make the case to British readers for an end to British rule as well as the case for radical social justice and internationalism.

He returned to India after the Second World War where he became an important part of the Indian literary and artistic communities. He intervened heavily in the debates about keeping English as a national language, worked to promote English departments across the country and spoke at numerous conferences about the relevance of Indian literature and art. He founded *Marg*, the publication of the Modern Architectural Research Group, which became one of the premier journals on art and architectural history in India.

He was a fellow of the Lalit Kala



Akademi and the Sahitya Akademi, a laureate of the International Peace Prize, and a Padma Bhushan. He also became involved with the Indian People's Theatre Association (IPTA) and the All-India Progressive Writers' Association (AIPWA), both of which promoted radical art and experimentation in the service of social change.

Anand died in 2004 at the ripe age of 99, having left a remarkable legacy of activism, creativity, and internationalism. Stokely Carmichael, an African-American and leader of the Black Panther Party, said it was Mulk Raj Anand's *Untouchable* which best explained the psychological and personal effects of racism in America. Carmichael's comment best explains the work of Anand and his importance to a modern India.

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